BONUS 3 · INTERNOMICS

The Field Playbooks

Internomics: How to See the Game Behind Every Interaction

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The Field Playbooks

Bonus 3 · Internomics for leaders, for sales and negotiation, and for relationships and family

Same eleven models. Different arenas.

The game behind a team meeting is not the game behind a pricing call. And neither one looks like the game at your kitchen table. The models don’t change. What changes is which games show up most often.

So pick your playbook. Or read all three.

Each one covers the five games you’ll meet most in that part of life. Each game gets a name you can remember. Learn the names and something useful happens. Within a week you’ll catch yourself in the middle of one and think, “Oh. This is that.”

That moment of recognition is the whole point. You can’t play a game well until you can see it.

Playbook 1: Internomics for Leaders

When you lead, you are never just a player. You are part of everyone else's game.

Your team studies you. They learn what you reward and what you punish. They learn what you'll fix for them and what you'll let fail. Your predictability and your incentives shape their choices long before you say a word in a meeting.

That is real power. It also means many of the problems you see on your team were taught by the system you run.

The Five Games You'll Meet Most

Game 1: The Silent Yes

What it looks like: You present a plan and ask, "Any concerns?" Everyone nods. Two weeks later the plan is stalled and you hear the real objections secondhand.

The game underneath: Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs. Your team knows things you don't. They also hold beliefs about what happens to people who disagree with you in public. The silence isn't agreement. It's a rational response to what they believe the room rewards.

Spot it early:

- Agreement comes fast and nobody asks a single question.
- The same two people speak in every meeting.
- You hear concerns in the hallway that never surfaced at the table.

Your play:

- Ask a question that assumes risk exists. "What's the most likely way this fails?"
- Collect concerns before the meeting in one-on-ones where the cost of speaking is lower.
- Thank the first person who disagrees. Out loud. Then act on what they said if it holds up.

The trap to avoid: Don't read a quiet room as a convinced room.

Game 2: The Last-Minute Fire

What it looks like: Every deadline turns into a crisis. Late on the last day you step in and save it. Everyone is grateful. Next month it happens again.

The game underneath: Model 5: See the Equilibrium. The team waits because you always rescue. You rescue because the team always waits. Nobody chose this pattern. It's stable anyway. And stable doesn't mean good.

Spot it early:

- Work arrives on your desk hours before it's due. Never days.
- People say "I figured you'd want to look at it" instead of finishing it.
- You feel needed and exhausted at the same time.

Your play:

- Name the pattern without blame. “I think I’ve trained us to wait for me.”
- Move your review earlier and make it a fixed checkpoint everyone can see.
- Let one low-stakes deadline land without your rescue. Then debrief it together.

The trap to avoid: Don’t mistake being the hero for being the leader.

Game 3: The Orphan Task

What it looks like: Everyone agrees the client needs a call today. The meeting ends. Tomorrow someone asks, “Did anyone call them?” Silence. Sales thought service had it. Service thought sales had it.

The game underneath: Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem. This is the project nobody owned. Nobody opposed the work. The group never set a shared expectation about who would act. That’s a coordination failure and not a character flaw.

Spot it early:

- Meetings end with “we should” instead of a name.
- Action items have no owner and no time.
- Your first instinct is “Nobody here takes initiative.”

Your play:

- End every decision with one sentence. “Dana owns this by 3 PM.”
- Say it where everyone hears it so everyone knows that everyone knows.
- Before you judge anyone’s effort ask a better question. “Was there a clear assignment?”

The trap to avoid: Don’t run a motivation speech to fix a clarity problem.

Game 4: The Poster on the Wall

What it looks like: You tell the team you want collaboration. Then you rank people publicly every month and pay bonuses only to the top performers. People guard their leads. You schedule a teamwork workshop. Nothing changes.

The game underneath: Model 11: Change the Game. The speech says cooperate. The scoreboard says your coworkers are your competitors. People follow the scoreboard. The question isn’t how to persuade them. It’s what your system actually rewards.

Spot it early:

- Your values and your metrics point in different directions.
- Good people behave in ways that confuse you.
- The same “culture problem” survives every new initiative.

Your play:

- Write down what earns a bonus or praise or promotion here. Compare it to what you say you want.
- Reward the behavior you're asking for. Shared wins. Help given. Problems surfaced early.
- Ask the team which rule they would change first. They know.

The trap to avoid: Don't blame players for playing the game you designed.

Game 5: The Open Door Nobody Uses

What it looks like: You tell everyone your door is always open. Nobody brings you bad news. You find out about problems after they've grown.

The game underneath: Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility. "My door is open" is cheap talk. What makes it credible is what happened to the last person who walked through it with a problem. Your team remembers that much better than your words.

Spot it early:

- The only news you hear is good news.
- People soften every problem into "a small thing."
- Someone who once raised an issue seems quieter now.

Your play:

- Back the words with a costly signal. Reward the bearer of bad news in a way others can see.
- Share a mistake of your own first. It lowers the cost for everyone else.
- Respond to the next problem with a question before a reaction. "What do you need from me?"

The trap to avoid: Don't repeat the invitation louder when the problem is what happens after people accept it.

Your Arena Audit

1. Which pattern of mine has my team learned to plan around?

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2. What does our scoreboard reward that I'd never say out loud?

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3. Where did a decision end last week without a name and a time attached?

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4. What do I believe my team knows that they may not actually know?

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5. What happened to the last person who brought me bad news?

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6. Which recurring crisis might be an equilibrium I'm part of?

One habit to start this week

End every meeting with the same question. “Who owns what by when?” Don’t leave until each item has one name and one time. Say them out loud so the whole room hears.

Playbook 2: Internomics for Sales & Negotiation

Sales and negotiation are games of information and credibility.

The buyer knows their budget and their alternatives and who really decides. You know your costs and your flexibility. Each of you is guessing about the other. Words fill the gap. But words are cheap. What moves a deal is what makes those words believable.

And most sales relationships aren't one-shot deals. They're repeated games with a reputation riding on every round.

The Five Games You'll Meet Most

Game 6: The Polite Stall

What it looks like: The meeting goes well. The buyer likes the product. Then you hear, "Let me think about it." You follow up three times. Nothing.

The game underneath: Model 2: See the Payoffs. You assumed the buyer's payoff was a good product at a fair price. Their real payoff may be not looking foolish to their boss. Or avoiding the work of switching. Or safety. "Let me think about it" makes sense once you see what they're actually protecting.

Spot it early:

- Enthusiasm in the room but no next step on the calendar.
- Questions shift from features to risk. "What if it doesn't work?"
- Another person's name keeps coming up.

Your play:

- Ask what a good outcome looks like for them personally. Not just for the company.
- Ask directly. "What would make this a hard decision for you?"
- Lower the real cost they face. A trial. A clear exit. Help building the case for their boss.

The trap to avoid: Don't keep selling the product when the obstacle is a payoff you haven't seen.

Game 7: The Early Discount

What it looks like: The buyer asks for the price. They pause. You hear yourself say, "But we could probably do something on that." They haven't even objected yet.

The game underneath: Model 3: Think in Responses. Your move is only half the move. Discounting before anyone asks feels generous. But what does it make them do next? It tells them the price is soft. Their best response is to push.

Spot it early:

- Silence after a number makes you uncomfortable.

- You offer flexibility to fill the pause.
- Your deals keep closing below the price you opened with.

Your play:

- State the price. Then stop talking.
- Before any concession ask, “If I do this, what will they likely do next?”
- If you move on price, tie it to something real. A longer term. A larger order. A change in scope.

The trap to avoid: Don’t judge a move by how it feels to make. Judge it by what it causes.

Game 8: The Concession Ladder

What it looks like: Every negotiation runs the same script. They counter. You give a little. They counter again. You give a little more. Repeat customers seem to know exactly how far they can push.

The game underneath: Model 4: Manage Predictability. If the other person knows you always concede after their first counteroffer, they don’t have to wonder whether to push. Your pattern has become part of their strategy. You taught them the game.

Spot it early:

- You make the same number of concessions in every deal.
- Your concessions shrink in the same predictable steps.
- A returning buyer opens with “Come on. You know you can do better.”

Your play:

- Ask yourself what your last five deals have taught people about you.
- Make concessions depend on something. Trade. Don’t just give.
- Be predictable where it builds trust. Quality. Delivery. Honesty. Be less predictable about how far you’ll move.

The trap to avoid: Don’t become erratic to fix a pattern. Become deliberate.

Game 9: The Final Final Offer

What it looks like: “This is our final offer.” A week later there’s a new one. Or you’re on the other side. The buyer says, “My hands are tied. Corporate won’t go higher.”

The game underneath: Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game. “Final” means little if the speaker can still change their mind. A commitment only changes the game when something actually binds it. So the useful question is simple. What makes this commitment real?

Spot it early:

- The word “final” arrives with nothing that makes it costly to reverse.
- “I can’t” shows up exactly when “I don’t want to” would be awkward.

- You've said "final" yourself and then moved.

Your play:

- When you hear "my hands are tied" ask what ties them. A policy? A budget cycle? A person you could talk to?
- Only call something final when it truly is. Then hold.
- Use real commitments honestly. A published price list. A genuine deadline you explain.

The trap to avoid: Never threaten a walk-away you won't actually take.

Game 10: The Last Deal Mindset

What it looks like: You squeeze one more point out of a long-time client. You win the round. Next year they quietly invite two of your competitors to bid.

The game underneath: Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. A move that wins a one-shot game can lose a repeated one. Most clients, partners and suppliers will see you again. Every deal teaches them what to expect from you next time. Reputation is their prediction of your next move.

Spot it early:

- You think about this quarter and not the next three years.
- You feel a small win as a small relief instead of a step forward.
- The relationship gets more formal and more guarded after each deal.

Your play:

- Before you push ask, "What will they expect from me next time?"
- Leave something on the table on purpose when the relationship is worth more than the margin.
- When you make a mistake repair it fast and visibly. Repair is a strategic move.

The trap to avoid: Don't win the round and lose the game.

Your Arena Audit

1. What have my last five negotiations taught people about how far I'll move?

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2. What does this buyer care about that never appears on the proposal?

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3. Which of my "final" positions would actually hold?

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4. What do they know that I don't? And what do I know that they don't?

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5. What makes my promises credible beyond my own words?

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6. Which client would I treat differently if I remembered I'll see them again next year?

One habit to start this week

Before every call write one line at the top of your notes. “What will they expect from me next time?” Read it once before you dial. Read it again before you agree to anything.

Playbook 3: Internomics for Relationships & Family

Family is the longest repeated game you'll ever play.

There's no final round. The people at your table will remember how today went. Every response you make teaches them what to expect from you tomorrow. And the patterns you build together can last for decades.

That's the hard part. It's also the hopeful part. A pattern that was learned can be changed.

The Five Games You'll Meet Most

Game 11: The Argument About Something Else

What it looks like: You're fighting about the dishes. Again. It gets heated in a way the dishes don't deserve. Neither of you can explain why it matters so much.

The game underneath: Model 1: See the Game. You're talking about the words while the real game sits underneath them. Maybe it's about feeling respected. Maybe it's about who carries the invisible load. The dishes are the board. They aren't the game.

Spot it early:

- The intensity doesn't match the topic.
- The same fight comes back with different props.
- Someone says "always" or "never."

Your play:

- Pause and ask yourself what's really going on here.
- Ask them gently. "I don't think this is about the dishes. What is it about for you?"
- Address the real game. Then the dishes usually take care of themselves.

The trap to avoid: Don't win the argument about the dishes and miss the one that matters.

Game 12: The Chase and Retreat

What it looks like: One partner feels unappreciated and complains. The other feels criticized and withdraws. The withdrawal causes more complaining. The complaining causes more withdrawal. Each of you is sure the other one started it.

The game underneath: Model 5: See the Equilibrium. You pursue. They withdraw. You pursue harder. They withdraw further. Each move is a response to the other. The loop is stable even though neither of you wants it.

Spot it early:

- You can predict the next three moves of the conversation.
- Both of you feel like the reasonable one.
- The question in your head is "Who's to blame?"

Your play:

- Change the question to “Why do we keep ending up here?”
- Describe the loop together as something you’re both stuck in. Not something one person did.
- Change your own move first. Pursue less. Or withdraw less. One changed move can break a loop.

The trap to avoid: Don’t wait for them to change first. That’s how the loop stays stable.

Game 13: The Scorekeeping Loop

What it looks like: “I did the school run three times this week.” “Well I handled your mother’s birthday.” Every kindness gets logged. Every slip gets remembered. Being generous starts to feel like losing.

The game underneath: Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Repeated games reward cooperation and fair response. But when every slip triggers retaliation one mistake can spiral. Misunderstandings are noise. A strategy with no room for forgiveness is fragile.

Spot it early:

- You hold back a kind act because “they didn’t do it for me.”
- Old mistakes come up in new arguments.
- Small misreads get treated as deliberate.

Your play:

- Give the benefit of the doubt on the small stuff. Noise isn’t betrayal.
- Repair quickly when you slip. Name it. Fix it. Move on.
- Forgive without forgetting. Keep boundaries where a real pattern exists.

The trap to avoid: Don’t confuse keeping score with keeping things fair.

Game 14: The Empty Threat

What it looks like: “If you do that one more time you’re grounded for six months.” Your child does it one more time. You both know six months isn’t happening.

The game underneath: Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game. A threat is only as good as the future decision behind it. Carrying out six months of punishment would be miserable for you too. Your child anticipates that. A smaller consequence you’ll actually enforce changes behavior more.

Spot it early:

- Consequences grow bigger as your patience shrinks.
- Your kids keep going after the warning.
- You hear yourself say “I mean it this time.”

Your play:

- Only state consequences you will actually carry out. Calmly.
- Choose small and clear over big and dramatic.
- Follow through the first time. That's what makes the next warning credible.

The trap to avoid: Don't threaten what you won't do.

Game 15: The Nightly Rematch

What it looks like: Every evening your child asks for more screen time. You say no. They argue. You argue back. They escalate. Sometimes you give in. So tomorrow they try again.

The game underneath: Model 11: Change the Game. You're renegotiating the same deal every night. And giving in now and then teaches that arguing sometimes pays. You don't need a better argument. You need a better game.

Spot it early:

- The same negotiation happens at the same time every day.
- The outcome depends on how tired you are.
- You win most nights and still dread it.

Your play:

- Set the rule once at a calm moment. Make it clear and visible.
- Let the rule do the work. "It's not me. It's the plan we agreed on."
- Involve them in the design where you can. Like "one cuts and the other chooses" for dividing the cake.

The trap to avoid: Don't keep playing a game you have the power to redesign.

Your Arena Audit

1. What fight keeps coming back with different props?

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2. What loop are we both stuck in? What's my move in it?

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3. Where am I keeping score instead of building trust?

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4. Which consequence have I threatened that I've never carried out?

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5. Which nightly negotiation could become a simple rule instead?

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6. What are the people I love learning to expect from me?

One habit to start this week

When you feel the old pattern start each day ask yourself one question before you respond. “What’s my usual move here?” Then make a different one. Just once a day.

Across Every Arena

Fifteen games. Three arenas. One skill underneath all of them.

The skill is a loop. Model the game. Act. Observe what actually happens. Update your read. Your first model will often be wrong. The person you thought cared about money cares about status. The loop you thought they started turns out to be one you both feed. That's fine. The goal isn't to be right on the first read. It's to get less wrong every time.

Every play in these guides passes the same test. Is it honest? Does it respect the other person's right to choose? Would you be comfortable if they saw exactly what you were doing and why? "Will this work?" and "Should I do it?" are separate questions. Ask both. Internomics helps you see the game more clearly. It never gives you permission to play it unfairly.

You won't remember every name. You don't need to. Pick the three games that showed up in your life this week. Watch for them. Recognition comes before strategy.

And when you're stuck in any arena come back to the question that started it all.

> **"What game am I playing?"**